

TIOBE Index March 2026: How 20+ Search Engines Rank the World's Programming Languages

Methodology: Ratings are based on search-engine hit counts across Google, Bing, Wikipedia, Amazon, and 20+ other sites.

Python Holds #1 at 21.25% but C Surges to #2 with the Largest Gain

Rank '26	Rank '25	Language	Rating	YoY
1	1	Python	21.25%	-2.59%
2	4	C	11.55%	+2.02%
3	2	C++	8.18%	-2.90%
4	3	Java	7.99%	-2.37%
5	5	C#	6.36%	+1.49%
6	6	JavaScript	3.45%	-0.01%
7	9	Visual Basic	2.50%	-0.02%
8	8	SQL	2.00%	-0.57%
9	16	R	1.88%	+0.94%
10	10	Delphi/Object Pascal	1.80%	-0.36%

Rank '26	Rank '25	Language	Rating	YoY
11	24	Perl	1.75%	+1.05%
12	12	Scratch	1.63%	-0.03%
13	11	Fortran	1.45%	-0.25%
14	14	Rust	1.31%	+0.09%
15	15	MATLAB	1.29%	+0.31%
16	7	Go	1.29%	-1.49%
17	17	Assembly language	1.29%	+0.42%
18	13	PHP	1.23%	-0.25%
19	18	Ada	1.10%	+0.25%
20	26	Swift	1.04%	+0.44%

Perl Jumps 13 Spots, R Climbs 7, and Go Drops 9 -- The Biggest Rank Shifts of 2026

MAJOR GAINERS

Perl ↑ +13 spots (24th → 11th)

R ↑ +7 spots (16th → 9th)

Swift ↑ +6 spots (26th → 20th)

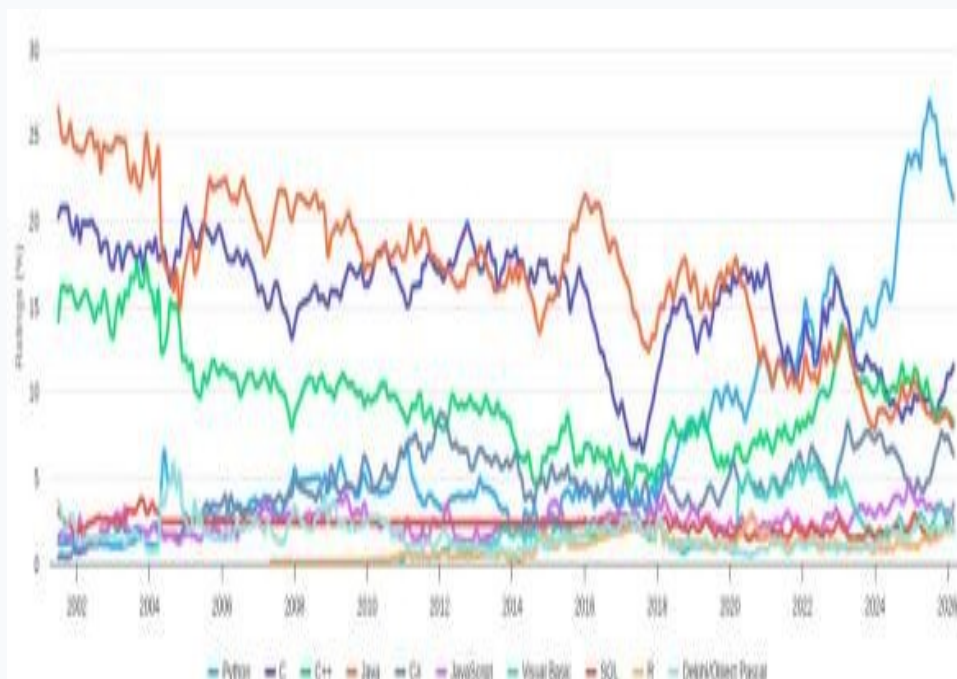
MAJOR LOSERS

Go ↓ -9 spots (7th → 16th)

C++ ↓ -1 spot (2nd → 3rd)

Java ↓ -1 spot (3rd → 4th)

From Lisp at #2 in 1986 to Python at #1 in 2026: How Language Rankings Shifted Over Time



Language	2026	2016	2006	1996	1986
Python	1	5	8	17	-
C	2	2	2	1	1
C++	3	3	3	2	9
Java	4	1	1	31	-
C#	5	4	7	-	-
JavaScript	6	8	10	33	-
Go	10	60	-	-	-
Ada	14	25	16	6	3
Lisp	26	26	14	8	2

Python Wins Language of the Year 6 Times -- More Than Any Other Language

Year	Winner
2025	C#
2024	Python
2023	C#
2022	C++
2021	Python
2020	Python
2019	C
2018	Python
2016	Go

Key Insights

- Python has won 6 times (2007, 2010, 2018, 2020, 2021, 2024).
- C# is surging with two recent wins (2023, 2025).
- Go won in 2016, preceding its current decline in rankings.

Note: The 2017 winner is not available in the source data.

The Top 4 Languages Hold 49% of the Index: What This Means for Your Tech Stack

Concentration Risk: Python, C, C++, and Java account for 48.97% of all ratings. Betting outside these top ecosystems introduces higher risk in hiring and tooling availability.

Python's Trajectory: While dominant at 21.25%, Python saw the largest year-over-year drop among the top 5 (-2.59%). Monitor this trend closely before committing to monolithic Python architectures.

C's Resurgence: C gained +2.02%, jumping from 4th to 2nd. Core systems programming remains vital and entrenched.

Legacy Rebound: Languages like Perl, R, and Fortran are seeing unexpected growth, serving deep, specialized niches in science and infrastructure.

Go's Decline: Dropping from 7th to 16th is a warning sign. Teams considering Go should evaluate if alternatives like Rust (up to 14th) offer better long-term viability.